

Gila monster

Heloderma suspectum

Solidly built, strong, slow, solitary, and secretive, the Gila (pronounced “hee-luh”) is North America’s largest native lizard—and one of very few that are venomous. Toxins from the Gila’s modified salivary glands flow into a victim by capillary action along grooved teeth in the lower jaw, aided by its tenaciously chewing grip. As a result, the Gila has few natural predators.

Supersize meal

Gila monsters spend 90 percent of their time resting in a den in an appropriated old burrow, among roots, or under rocks. They feed on bird and reptile eggs, small mammals, birds (especially nestlings), reptiles such as lizards, and frogs and other amphibians, as well as bugs and worms. Given its energy-saving habits, and the ability to store fat in its tail, a sizeable meal lasts a Gila for weeks. A young Gila can eat one-half its own body weight in a sitting, an adult one-third. As a result, some Gilas eat as few as six times in a year.



A Gila **bite** is painful but rarely fatal to humans

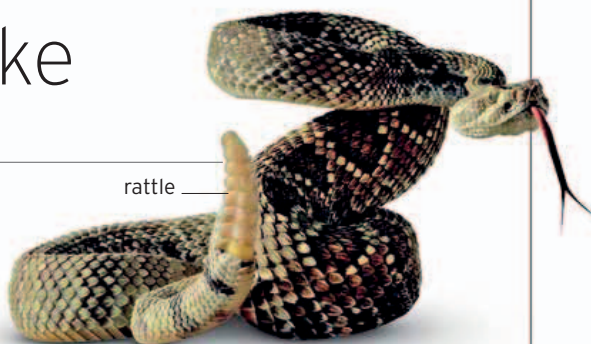


Mojave rattlesnake

Crotalus scutulatus

A member of the pit viper family, this rattlesnake has bowl-like pits below the eyes that detect infrared (heat) in warm-blooded animals. Its potent venom is used both to subdue prey, such as rats and mice, and to defend itself. The warning rattle from which its common name is derived increases in size each time the snake sheds its skin.

The Mojave rattlesnake differs from its famous close cousin, the western diamondback rattlesnake, in that the back markings fade earlier toward the tail and its white tail rings are wider than the black ones.



△ MOJAVE GREEN

Some Mojave rattlesnakes have an olive-green tinge—locals call them Mojave greens.

- ↔ 3–4ft (1–1.2m)
- ⚖ 4–9lb (1.8–4.1kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🐭 Small mammals, lizards
- 🏠 🌿 🌳
- 📍 SW. North America, Central America

Couch's spadefoot

Scaphiopus couchii

The spadefoot is named after the hard pads on its hind feet, which it uses to dig burrows in the sand. The toad spends months deep underground to avoid dry conditions. While underground, it retains the toxins that are usually expelled in urine. This creates a high chemical concentration in the toad’s body, allowing water to be absorbed from the soil through its permeable skin.

Breeding takes place in the wet season. The toads come to the surface after the first heavy rains, and females lay their eggs in temporary pools. They hatch within 36 hours, and tadpoles mature into toadlets in 40 days.



△ FEED AND BREED

As well as breeding, the toads spend the nights above ground hunting for as much prey as they can find.

- ↔ 2–4in (5–10cm)
- ☁ Rainy season
- ⊗ Common
- 🐭 Insects, spiders
- 🏠 🌿 🌳
- 📍 S. US, Mexico